



SOCI 545: Sociology of Population

Fall 2025

Classroom: LEA 834

Time: Wednesdays 8:30 AM – 10:30 AM (yes, sorry)

Professor: Orsola Torrissi

Email: orsola.torrissi@mcgill.ca

I typically respond to emails within 24 hours (weekdays). If you have not heard from me after 24 hours, you may email me again to make sure I received your message.

Student hours (SH): Fridays, 4:45-6 PM

Office: Room 814, LEA

Appointment: Please schedule an appointment at this [link](#).

Note: Appointments are 15 minutes long. If you require more time, feel free to book two consecutive slots. Please indicate whether you prefer to meet in person or via Zoom, and briefly mention the topic you would like to discuss.

1 Course Description

All and each one of us (to be fair, anything is) is a member of a population. However, not every one of us (to be fair, quite few) thinks systematically about the population to which we belong, or populations as such. Yet, the characteristics of the population we belong to, or any population in general, and the demographic processes that generate them are inextricably linked to all social, economic, political, and even environmental, violent threats and national-security issues we face. Demography is the basis of all planning activities, developmental processes and social change. Understanding how population characteristics interact with socio-political issues will help you understand the root causes of many societal issues and the public discourse around them.

This course is designed to provide you with foundations in demographic topics (fertility, migration and mortality), thinking and analysis of social change from a population perspective. We will do so by (i) examining key theories that have shaped and still shape the field, (ii) discussing emerging critical issues in population dynamics, such as ageing populations, new pathways into adulthood, changing family formations, reproductive autonomy, data and measurement issues, and (iii) learning how demography operates as a key tool for generating knowledge about many social outcomes including education, health, religion, the legal system, and even dating!

The course takes a global perspective, focusing on both high-income and low-income settings to draw relevant contrasts, and comparisons and spark critical questions about current and future demographic developments.

2 Course Goals

The course objectives include:

- Provide a broad understanding of the major historical and contemporary global population processes.
- Appreciate the interrelationships between demographic phenomena and social change.
- Hone students' ability to carefully read, synthesise, and critique key articles that have transformed our understanding of population dynamics in a variety of areas.
- Provide examples of substantive applications of more advanced demographic techniques or better understand their origins and purpose.

- Enhance students' ability to write strong essays and present research on a diverse array of questions about these demographic processes. As such, this course provides particularly good training to take the area exam in population dynamics in the Department of Sociology.

3 Assignments and Grading

Your success in this class is important to me. You learn from, me, your peers and I learn from you! Hence, assignments for this course are thought to incentivise continuous engagement with the material, regular feedback and peer collaboration.

Readings are the foundation of this course. You are expected to engage with them on a weekly basis.

1) Engagement with course readings – 10% of final grade

All Required readings are posted on [Perusall](#), a collaborative annotation tool and online platform that allows you to make comments, pose questions, and engage in discussion with each other about the course material. You are expected to have read and commented on all the assigned material at least 24 hours before each class, i.e., by **10:00 AM on Tuesdays**.

Since quantity does not always correlate with quality, you will be graded on the quality of your comments and questions. Only comments made by 10:00 AM on Tuesdays will be considered as part of the engagement grade.

2) Presentations of article summaries – 15% of final grade

By Friday 29 August, you will sign-up or, in case, be assigned to provide oral summaries for some articles during class. You can sign-up [here](#) (first-come-first-served basis, 2 students each week max). The length of the summaries will be of about 8-12 minutes depending on the length and density of the article. These oral summaries should:

- Clearly and accurately delineate the main points made by the authors in each article
- Specifically address areas of confusion or clarification questions by peers in Perusall
- Stimulate subsequent informed discussion in the class

Grades will be assessed on all three points above (i.e., the accuracy and clarity of these presentations, engagement with peer questions, and ability to generate discussion).

3) Class discussion – 15% of final grade

Each week after the presentations, there will be an in-person discussion of the week's material during normal class time. You are required to have completed the readings and identified their key questions before attending these discussions. The criteria for assessing your contribution to class discussion are in the table below.

Table 1 – Marking criteria for class discussion

CRITERIA	EXCELLENT	ADEQUATE	NEEDS WORK
Participation in class	Student initiates contributions at least once each class.	Student initiates contribution at least in some classes.	Student never initiates contributions and always needs instructor to solicit input.
Quality of comments	Comments are insightful and constructive; reference specific pages/passages in the readings; engage with classmates without dominating. Comments are balanced between general impressions, opinions, and specific, thoughtful contributions. Stimulate discussion with the instructor and classmates.	Comments are sometimes constructive, with occasional signs of insight. Grasp of appropriate terminology is demonstrated. Comments are typically general and only occasionally refer to readings.	Comments are uninformative, overly reliant on opinion and personal taste (e.g., “I love it”, “I hate it”), or anecdotal experience. Lacks appropriate terminology and engagement with readings.
Listening Skills	Student listens attentively and respectfully to others, as indicated by comments that build on others’ remarks. Student hears what others say and contributes in a respectful manner.	Student is mostly attentive when others speak. Occasionally needs encouragement or reminders from the instructor to stay focused.	Student is often inattentive and needs repeated reminders to focus. May make disruptive comments or appear disengaged (e.g., sleeping).

***Note** – The content of this course may, at some point, include topics that are difficult for some people to confront or discuss. As the course convenor, I cannot anticipate what those topics are, or who will be affected, but I can be sensitive and work with students who let me know of their needs. If there is a topic you are unable to discuss or need to be warned about, please notify me so we can make appropriate arrangements for your work. We will endeavour to be sensitive and considerate. However, we cannot prevent all students from being exposed to topics or ideas that they find objectionable or offensive. For more on these issues see Section 5 Course Policies at the end of document

4) Essays (2) – 40% (each 20%) of final grade

You will write 2 essays addressing one of the weekly topics covered in class up until the essay deadline (see below). You may respond directly to the suggested questions for each week or develop a related question of your own. If the latter, you will need approval from the instructor. The question you are addressing must be clearly stated at the top of each essay. These papers should provide a critical analysis of the readings and how they contribute to the debates introduced in class. A good essay is not a summary but an analysis that identifies major themes that cut across the readings of the week. I will provide an outline of a sample paper if necessary.

You are expected to draw on material beyond the syllabus readings in your responses to these questions. You can consult with me for reading suggestions, in case. In general, you should have some extra-syllabus

references, ideally 5-8 articles and you are required to incorporate and correctly reference at least two of the assigned articles. All references need to be accessible on the web (i.e., ensure they have associated DOIs).

Essays should be between 2,500-3,000 words max, excluding references. I do not mind fonts or double spacing, but I like easy fonts like Arial/Times New Roman/Garamond. Generally, please ensure readability. Essays are to be uploaded to MyCourses by the following dates:

- Essay 1 (covering a topic from weeks 1-5): **October 10 @ 12:00 pm**
- Essay 2 (covering a topic from weeks 6-12): **December 5 @12:00 pm**

Kindly name your Word/PDF document as follows: *FIRST NAME_SOCI 545_Essay Number*. See the policy on the limited acceptable way you may use generative AI to assist you in developing these essays.

Table 2 – Marking criteria for essays

CRITERIA	EXCELLENT	ADEQUATE	NEEDS WORK
Structure and clarity of expression	Excellent, logically developed argument; very well written	Logically presented argument; clearly expressed	Poorly developed argument; meaning not necessarily or entirely clear.
Awareness of the literature	Excellent or very good use of wide range of literature to support argument/points	Good use of wide range of literature to support arguments	Use of narrow range of standard literature to support arguments
Knowledge and basic understanding	Excellent or very good understanding and exposition of relevant issues; well informed; good awareness of nuances and complexities	Shows awareness of issues but tendency to simplify matters	Superficial understanding of issue; no more than expected from attendance at lectures; some irrelevant or confused material
Argument/critical analysis and conclusion	Well-constructed arguments with appropriate use of theory/conceptual framework; questioning, unbiased approach; clear evidence of independent thought; good demonstration of originality of thought	Appropriate choice and use of theory/conceptual framework; attempts analysis	Weak understanding or use of chosen theory/conceptual framework; too descriptive and/or analysis too superficial

5) Group research poster and presentation – 20% of final grade

In a group of 2-3 students, you will identify a meaningful demographically-oriented research question of your choice and work toward a scientific poster as if you had been accepted for a “flash” presentation at the Population Association of America (PAA) Annual Conference. I would like it to be the goal of everyone in the class to use the weekly readings to develop a research question on *future* critical demographic outcomes, trends and patterns. You can think of this exercise as an advanced research proposal stemming from the gaps we identified in class. Ideally, the final poster will display (in non-strict order) the following components:

- **Introduction and motivation:** Brief synthesis of the literature related to your topic and motivating sentences for exploring it
- **Context:** Information about the context and population of interest
- Research questions and hypotheses: Specific research questions and theory-based hypotheses
- **Data/Methods:** Description of data sources useful to answer the question or data collection needs
- **Visuals:** A few panels providing visual material (tables/graphs) that can help understand the topic

The specific topic of the poster will have to be different from the one you have addressed for your Essays, but the broad domain can be the same (e.g., you can write and have a paper on family-related topics, one on the destitutionalisation of marriage theory and one on low fertility). Each group member will obtain the same grade and only one poster will be needed per group. Each group member will have to present a section of the poster. All details will be discussed, and we will allocate class time to form groups and work on the poster/presentations. The final session for the course will be dedicated to showcasing and assessing the poster presentations. Poster presentations cannot be missed. If you are in a situation that might require you to miss the assignment, please inform me and your group members promptly. October 31st is the deadline for forming groups.

To summarise all the above, the grading scheme and provisional deadlines for this class is below:

Assessment Component	Weight	Due Date
Engagement with course readings (Perusall)	10%	Weekly
Presentations of article summaries	15%	Weekly
Class discussion	15%	Weekly
Essay #1	20%	Oct. 10
Essay #2	20%	Dec. 5
Group research poster and presentation*	20%	Last class

*The deadline for forming groups: October 31st

3.1 Re-grading

Students who wish to contest a grade must do so in writing (by email) providing the reasoning behind their challenge to the grade received within two weeks of the day on which the grades are returned. I will then re-evaluate, but also reserve the right to raise or lower the grade.

3.2 Re-Assignment make-up/delays

Sometimes our lives interfere with our coursework. This is a normal, expected thing that happens for some students every semester. If you find yourself struggling to complete readings or assignments, please come to office hours so we can discuss academic accommodation options that can help you make the most out of the semester. However, please note that without prior discussions, proven emergency and/or medical circumstances, it will not be possible for me to help. If you are absent for such reasons, I will try my best to be accommodating (e.g., give extensions or arrange an alternative date for your presentations), provided that the absence is properly justified and, when necessary, documented. No late assignments will be accepted without prior discussion with me and, if needed, proper documentation

If you know you will miss either presentations, essay deadlines or the final group work do not take this course.

4 Course Policies

4.1 Attendance

If you want to do well in this class and understand the material, it is essential that you come to class. You will notice that the pace will be quite fast and we will cover a good amount of theoretical literature,

applied research and contexts. Also, well... the class is very small, so it will be immediately clear to me if missing patterns emerge.

4.2 Screens in Classroom Policy

Most available [literature](#) shows that computers, telephones, and tablets can be detrimental to learning. I myself see that screens can distract me as well as the people around me. In your case, it is also very likely that screens impact class participation, an element of your final grade. As such, while I am not going to be imposing this on anyone as we are all grown up, I highly encourage you to limit the use of technology in the class and take advantage of the cool conversations we will have.

4.3 Use of Generative AI

One of the primary learning objectives for this course is to help you improve your ability to write strong, clear, accurate, and persuasive essays. In pursuit of this goal, you are permitted to use generative AI, such as ChatGPT, to assist with your research, but **you are not permitted to use it to write essays** for you.

You may use generative AI to help you:

- Brainstorm for ideas and generate an initial outline
- Get clarification or elaboration on key concepts and ideas
- Find additional references
- Summarise articles and readings
- Improve your writing by getting feedback on your use of vocabulary, making more coherent arguments, and reducing redundancies.

You may **NOT** use generative AI to:

- Write part or all of your essay. All parts of the essay writing must originate from you. Copying AI-generated text and claiming it as your own is plagiarism and will be treated as such according to the Academic Integrity Policy provided below.

Caveats on use of generative AI:

- Hallucinations and false information. Generative AI is well-known for confidently asserting made up information. You are responsible for the accuracy of your statements.
- Completely or partially invalid references. Generative AI also regularly invents references in part or in full. You must add DOIs to all of your references. Also, be aware that ChatGPT does not have access to articles after 2021 nor to many studies before the 1990s.

Implications for grading and assessment:

- You are required to add a statement at the end of each essay stating whether you used generative AI and, if so, for which permissible activities listed above. This declaration will not influence your grade.
- Hallmarks of good essay writing (and weaknesses of generative AI) include accuracy, originality, detailed and substantive (not superficial) arguments, clearly stated positions and opinions (not wishy-washy neutral statements), and appropriate integration of references. Hence, all of these attributes will be taken into consideration in your grade.
- You will be penalised 10 points for each partially or fully invalid reference.

4.4 Extraordinary Circumstances

In the event of extraordinary circumstances beyond the control of McGill University, assessment tasks in a course are subject to change, provided students are sent adequate and timely communications about the change.

4.5 Copyright

All slides, video recordings, lecture notes, etc. remain the instructor's intellectual property. As such, you may use these only for your own learning (and research, with proper referencing/citation) ends. You are not permitted to disseminate or share these materials; doing so may violate the instructor's intellectual property rights and could be cause for disciplinary action.

Instructor generated course materials (e.g., handouts, notes, summaries, exam questions, recorded lectures, etc.) are protected by law and may not be copied or distributed in any form or in any medium without explicit permission of the instructor. Note that infringements of copyright can be subject to follow up by the University under the Code of Student Conduct and Disciplinary Procedures.

4.6 Inclusive Learning Environment

As the instructor of this course, I endeavour to provide an inclusive learning environment. However, if you experience barriers to learning in this course, do not hesitate to discuss them with me and the Office for Students with Disabilities, 514-398-6009.

4.7 Language of Submission

In accord with McGill University's Charter of Students' Rights, students in this course have the right to submit in English or in French any written work that is to be graded.

Conformément à la Charte des droits de l'étudiant de l'Université McGill, chaque étudiant a le droit de soumettre en français ou en anglais tout travail écrit devant être noté (sauf dans le cas des cours dont l'un des objets est la maîtrise d'une langue). Les étudiants de ce cours peuvent rédiger tous leurs travaux (incluant les examens) en français, mais doivent pour ce faire obtenir la permission préalable de la professeure. Aucune permission rétroactive ne sera accordée. Indigenous Land Statement

McGill University is located on land which has long served as a site of meeting and exchange amongst Indigenous peoples, including the Haudenosaunee and Anishinaabe nations. McGill honours, recognises and respects these nations as the traditional stewards of the lands and waters on which we meet today.

4.8 Academic Integrity Policy

Just like writing a paper, copying other people's computer code constitutes plagiarism. Moreover, **data cleaning, coding and analysis are learned through trial and error**. Please do not under any circumstance copy another student's code. If you are found to have done so, you may be referred to the appropriate Dean. The instructors reserve the right to use software to compare the code that has been written by different students. Note that to support academic integrity, your assignments may be submitted to text-matching or other appropriate software (e.g., formula-, equation-, and graph-matching). McGill University values academic integrity. Therefore, all students must understand the meaning and consequences of cheating, plagiarism and other academic offences under the Code of Student Conduct and Disciplinary Procedures (see [here](#) for more information, approved by Senate on 29 January 2003).

L'université McGill attache une haute importance à l'honnêteté académique. Il incombe par conséquent à tous les étudiants de comprendre ce que l'on entend par tricherie, plagiat et autres infractions académiques, ainsi que les conséquences que peuvent avoir de telles actions, selon le Code de conduite de l'étudiant et des procédures disciplinaires (pour de plus amples renseignements, veuillez consulter le site [ici](#))

5 Class Schedule (Provisional)

Each class includes 3-4 Required readings. There is also a series of optional readings for any of you who may be particularly interested in a topic and/or want to easily identify additional resources that could be leveraged to write essays, prepare for presentations or know more about how cool Demography is.

Below, under each week's title, you will find the list of required and optional readings with hyperlinks available in electronic journals or on the web. Required articles are available on Perusall for comments. Optional readings are to be accessed through the hyperlinks below—so this Syllabus is key! If, for any reason, you have trouble accessing any hyperlinks, let me know and I will upload them on MyCourses. For some of the key papers, I provide below a summary that, hopefully, should make you excited to read the whole article, or the sections highlighted there. Presenters are encouraged to read the whole article(s).

Note that the scheduling of topics for the course listed below and associated readings are subject to change. Such changes, should they take place, will be announced ahead of time in class and through MyCourses. Students are responsible for keeping abreast of any changes made.

WEEK 1 – DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION THEORY

Note 1) No class discussion will take place in the first meeting for the course. The first class instead will involve a general introduction to the course and a lecture on the demographic transition. I expect you have at least skimmed through the Required readings, focusing on a few questions:

- What are some criticisms of the relevance of the DTT to countries only now experiencing demographic change? Which ones do you find more convincing and why?
- Is the Demographic Transition Model useful as a framework for evaluating demographic change in regions outside the Western world?
- Is it inevitable and desirable that all countries share the experiences of Europe and the United States to pass through a demographic transition?

Required readings

- Kirk, D. (1996). Demographic Transition Theory. *Population Studies*, 50(3), 361–387. [doi:10.1080/0032472031000149536](https://doi.org/10.1080/0032472031000149536) Key paper for understanding the pillar theory of the Demographic Transition (DTT). No need to focus on the details about specific countries, but be sure to absorb the basics: what the DTT says, why it is important in the history of human populations, and the potential link between mortality and fertility declines.
- Lee, R. (2003). The Demographic Transition: Three Centuries of Fundamental Change. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 17(4), 167–190. [Access here](#) Another classic paper that outlines the stages and implications of the DTT.
- Ryder, N. B. (1985). The cohort as a concept in the study of social change. *American Sociological Review*, 30(6). [doi:10.2307/2090964](https://doi.org/10.2307/2090964) An essential piece for grasping the role of the cohort in demography and social change.

Optional readings

Optional readings include recent contributions that reflect on the field of demography and suggest future directions. These may be of particular interest if you wish to engage more deeply with the theoretical and methodological frontiers of the discipline.

- Krieger, N. (2012). Who and What Is a “Population”? Historical Debates, Current Controversies, and Implications for Understanding “Population Health” and Rectifying Health Inequities. *The Milbank Quarterly*, 90(4), 634–681. [doi:10.1111/j.1468-0009.2012.00678.x](https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-0009.2012.00678.x)

- Pesando, L. M., Dorélien, A., St-Denis, X., & Santos, A. (2023). Demography as a Field: Where We Came From and Where We Are Headed. *Canadian Studies in Population*, 50(3), 4. doi:10.1007/s42650-023-00076-8
- Dorling, D., & Gietel-Basten, S. (2017). Why Demography Matters. *John Wiley & Sons*, Chapter 1. [Access here](#)
- Sigle, W. (2021). Demography's Theory and Approach: (How) Has the View from the Margins Changed? *Population Studies*, 75(sup1), 235–251. doi:10.1080/00324728.2021.1984550

Some great papers for “doing demography” historically, and today.

- Billari, F. C. (2015). Integrating Macro- and Micro-level Approaches in the Explanation of Population Change. *Population Studies*, 69(sup1), S11–S20. doi:10.1080/00324728.2015.1009712
- Kreager, P. (2008). Aristotle and Open Population Thinking. *Population and Development Review*, 34(4), 599–629. doi:10.1111/j.1728-4457.2008.00243.x

An article showcasing the importance of looking at recent social phenomena using a demographic perspective.

- Dowd, J. B., Andriano, L., Brazel, D. M., Rotondi, V., Block, P., Ding, X., ... & Mills, M. C. (2020). Demographic Science Aids in Understanding the Spread and Fatality Rates of COVID-19. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 117(18), 9696–9698. doi:10.1073/pnas.2004911117

WEEK 2 – THE POPULATION AND DEVELOPMENT DEBATE

Core Questions

- Trace the population and development debate in both the academic and public literatures. Has research or public opinion been most important in shaping our understanding of the relationship between population growth and economic development?
- Did anyone eventually ‘win’ the population and development debate? Does your answer differ if you consider different issues, e.g., food security, economic development, the environment, health, or women’s reproductive rights?
- How can we reconcile public fears about the “population bomb” and “demographic decline”?

Required readings

- Malthus, T. (1798). An Essay on the Principle of Population (first edition), Chapters 1–2. <http://www.gutenberg.org/files/4239/4239-h/4239-h.htm> Super important, but admittedly long. Focus only on the key ideas, especially the two postulates in Chapter 1 and what they jointly imply for population growth in Chapter 2.
- Ehrlich, P. R. (1968). Chapter 1: The Problem. in *The Population Bomb*. New York NY: Sierra Club. Depending on how interested you are in the debate, you can decide to spend no more than 10-15 minutes here as well as hours. Try nevertheless to get a sense of population concerns (at least from some) in the 1960s. You may wish to slow down when Ehrlich talks about the “doubling time”.
- Lam, D. (2011). How the World Survived the Population Bomb: Lessons From 50 Years of Extraordinary Demographic History. *Demography*, 48(4): 1231-1262. <http://link.springer.com/article/10.1007%2Fs13524-011-0070-z> Read this after Ehrlich’s. Again, no details need to be absorbed; zero in on 1) a review of why the 1960s were such an unusual decade for the world population, 2) what the main concerns were in the 1960s, and 3) how the world overcame these potential catastrophes. Here, focus especially on demographic factors and particularly on fertility decline.

- Becker, S. (2013). Has the World Really Survived the Population Bomb? *Demography*, 50(6):2173-81. <http://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11266-013-9511-1> Read this after Lam's as it is a commentary (or more, a critique). Do you agree?

Optional readings

Optional readings include more newspaper commentaries on the whole debate around the population-development debate:

- Kelley, A. (2001). The Population Debate in Historical Perspective: Revisionism Revisited. Chapter 2 in *Population Matters: Demographic Change, Economic Growth, and Poverty in the Developing World*, Nancy Birdsall, Allen C. Kelley, and Steven Sinding (eds). Oxford: Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/0199244073.003.0002> Good summary of all the above.
- Haberman, C. (2015). The Unrealized Horrors of Population Explosion. [Access here](#)
- Harvey, D. (2010). The Political Implications of Population-Resources Theory. [Access here](#)

A great paper that discusses the link between fertility responses to mortality shocks, which links back to the prior's week discussion:

- Nobles, J., Frankenberg, E., & Thomas, D. (2015). The effects of mortality on fertility: population dynamics after a natural disaster. *Demography*, 52(1), 15-38. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-014-0362-1>

WEEK 3 – MORTALITY CHANGES: CAUSES AND CONSEQUENCES

Core Questions

- What is the Epidemiological Transition? How valid is this conceptualisation as the starting point for understanding changes in mortality in the process of development?
- What is McKeown's hypothesis? Was he correct?
- Are the causes of mortality decline the same in currently high-income countries as they are currently low- and middle-income countries?
- How does declining mortality influence both the disease profile and population dynamics?
- What are the most important mechanisms linking women's education to lower child mortality?

Required readings

- Cutler, D., Deaton, A., & Lleras-Muney, A. (2006). The determinants of mortality. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 20(3), 97–120. [doi:10.3386/w11963](https://doi.org/10.3386/w11963) Start here with a paper written by economists.
- Omran, A. R. (1971). "The Epidemiologic Transition: A Theory of the Epidemiology of Population Change." *The Milbank Memorial Fund Quarterly*, 49(4), 509–538. [doi:10.1111/j.1468-0009.2005.00398.x](https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-0009.2005.00398.x) Move, here then. Do not worry about the length. The paper is well-organised around propositions. Propositions 1 and 4 summarise the DTT, largely. Proposition 2 is key – read closely!
- Gakidou, E., Cowling, K., Lozano, R., & Murray, C. J. (2010). Increased educational attainment and its effect on child mortality in 175 countries between 1970 and 2009: a systematic analysis. *The Lancet*, 376(9745), 959–974. [doi:10.1016/S0140-6736\(10\)61257-3](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(10)61257-3) End here with a paper written by public health experts on the link between mortality declines and education.

Optional readings

Optional readings include more in-depth discussions on the role of public health interventions in shaping mortality declines, a formal analysis I was involved in to understand the impact of violence on mortality, an important paper showing changing trends in mortality in the white-male American population since

the early 2000s, and a blog piece criticising it, and some other interesting articles tackling causes and consequences of (and cool data to assess) changes in mortality (and pain) in recent times.

- Cutler, D., & Miller, G. (2005). The role of public health improvements in health advances: The twentieth-century United States. *Demography*, 42(1), 1–22. [doi:10.1353/dem.2005.0002](https://doi.org/10.1353/dem.2005.0002)
- Aburto, J. M., Di Lego, V., Riffe, T., Kashyap, R., Van Raalte, A., & Torrissi, O. (2023). A global assessment of the impact of violence on lifetime uncertainty. *Science Advances*, 9(5), eadd9038. [doi:10.1126/sciadv.add9038](https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.add9038)
- Case, A., & Deaton, A. (2015). Rising morbidity and mortality in midlife among white non-Hispanic Americans in the 21st century. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(49), 15078–15083. [doi:10.1073/pnas.1518393112](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1518393112)
- Cohen, P. (2015). Age composition change accounts for about half of the Case and Deaton mortality finding. *Family Inequality (blog)*. [Access here](#)
- Mediazona and Meduza (2023). At least 47,000 Russian soldiers killed in Ukraine. A data investigation. <https://en.zona.media/article/2023/07/10/stats>
- Paglino, E., & Elo, I. T. (2024). Immigrant mortality advantage in the United States during the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic. *Demographic Research*, 50, 185. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC10861242/>
- Polizzi, A., & Dowd, J. (2024). Working-age mortality is still an important driver of stagnating life expectancy in the United States. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 121(4), e2318276121. [doi:10.1073/pnas.2318276121](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2318276121)
- Robles, P., Wang, V., & Dong, J. (2023). In China's Covid fog, deaths of scholars offer a clue. *The New York Times*. [Access here](#)
- Zajacova, A., Grol-Prokopczyk, H., & Zimmer, Z. (2021). Pain trends among American adults, 2002–2018: Patterns, disparities, and correlates. *Demography*, 58(2), 711–738. [doi:10.1215/00703370-8977691](https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-8977691)

WEEK 4 – AGEING SOCIETIES AND THE HUMAN LIFESPAN

Core Questions

- Is there a natural limit to human life expectancy? Will healthy life expectancy catch up to life expectancy or lag further behind?
- As societies age, will health and social security expenditures bankrupt governments? Or will there be unexpected benefits to having an older population?
- How may have COVID-19 influenced thinking about the human lifespan?

Required readings

- Olshansky, S. J., Carnes, B. A., & Désesquelles, A. (2001). Prospects for human longevity. *Science*, 291(5508), 1491–1492. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1126/science.291.5508.1491> This and Oeppen & Vaupel's need to be read one after the other with no break in the between. Hold your breath.
- Oeppen, J., & Vaupel, J. W. (2002). Broken limits to life expectancy. *Science*, 296(5570), 1029–1031. <http://dx.doi.org/10.1126/science.1069675>
- Lee, R., Mason, A., & members of the NTA Network. (2014). Is Low Fertility Really a Problem? Population Aging, Dependency, and Consumption. *Science*, 346(6206), 229–234. <https://doi.org/10.1126/science.1250542> A first discussion, from an economic perspective, of what low fertility may mean for national accounts.

- Kluge, F., Zagheni, E., Loichinger, E., & Vogt, T. (2014). The advantages of demographic change after the wave: fewer and older, but healthier, greener, and more productive? *PLoS One*, 9(9), e108501. <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0108501>
A second, more recent discussion, from a health and environment perspective, of what low fertility levels may mean.

Optional readings

Optional readings include a more recent update on Vaupel's theory (his last publication before he passed away), a fun, quick, easy read that nicely summarises the heated debate between Oeppen and Vaupel and Olshansky et al., a paper that utilises the epidemiological transition theory to compare and contrasts the health experiences of the two most populous countries in the world (before COVID19), as well as a review of Omran's theory.

- Vaupel, J. W., Villavicencio, F., & Bergeron-Boucher, M. P. (2021). Demographic perspectives on the rise of longevity. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 118(9), e2019536118. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2019536118>
- Couzin-Frankel, J. (2011). A pitched battle over life span. *Science*, 333(6042), 549-550. [10.1126/science.333.6042.549](https://doi.org/10.1126/science.333.6042.549)
- Dummer, T. J. B., & Cook, G. (2008). Health in China and India: A Cross-Country Comparison in a Context of Rapid Globalisation. *Social Science & Medicine*, 67(4), 590-605. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2008.04.019>
- Santosa, A., Wall, S., Fottrell, E., Högberg, U., & Byass, P. (2014). The development and experience of epidemiological transition theory over four decades: a systematic review. *Global Health Action*, 7(1), 23574. <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.3402/gha.v7.23574>

WEEK 5 – FERTILITY DECLINE: THE ROLE OF EDUCATION

Core Questions

- Which of the major theories advanced to explain fertility decline do you find most convincing and why?
- Trace the theoretical pathways through which mass education could lead to fertility decline. Which pathways are supported by the empirical evidence? Is women's education effective in reducing fertility?
- What does Caldwell's theory of wealth flows say? What do you think are its major insights? What does it fail to account for?

Required readings

- Mason, K. O. (1997). Explaining Fertility Transitions. *Demography*, 34(4): 443-454. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3038299> A classic that requires time – there is a lot of material here. Focus on the six theories of fertility decline (try to summarise each with one or two bullet points). In the “Four Errors in Our Thinking” section, notice the key points of the first three parts: that different transitions may have different causes, that mortality decline is a necessary but not sufficient condition, that even pre-transitional populations have controlled their fertility. Then explore the culmination in the 8 points “Toward a Better Theory” then skip to the Conclusion.
- Caldwell, J. (1980). Mass Education as a Determinant of the Timing of Fertility Decline. *Population and Development Review*, 6(2): 225-255. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/1972729>
An important paper that introduces the wealth flow theory and explains how mass education and its effect on the family economy may be seen as the primary determinant of changes in the timing of the onset of the fertility transition.

- Behrman, J. A. (2015). Does Schooling Affect Women's Desired Fertility? Evidence from Malawi, Uganda, and Ethiopia. *Demography*, 52(3): 787–809. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-015-0392-3>
A nice application to test the question (in settings where it matters and data may be scarcer).

Optional readings

Optional readings include some other – more or less recent – papers linking fertility reductions and education in Africa, south Asia and the US.

- Grant, M. (2015). The Demographic Promise of Expanded Female Education: Trends in the Age at First Birth in Malawi. *Population and Development Review*, 41(3), 409–438.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1728-4457.2015.00066.x>
- Axinn, W. G., & Barber, J. S. (2001). Mass Education and Fertility Transition. *American Sociological Review*, 66(4), 481–505. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3088919>
- Mark, N. D., & Wu, L. L. (2022). More comprehensive sex education reduced teen births: Quasi-experimental evidence. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 119(8), e2113144119.
<https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2113144119>

WEEK 6 – FERTILITY DECLINE: FAMILY PLANNING

Core Questions

- Does increasing access to family planning decrease fertility or is development the ‘best contraceptive’?
- What are some of the limitations of research “proving” that the use of contraception is the most important determinant of fertility decline? What types of studies help to overcome these limitations?
- How accurate is the concept of unmet need? Is it capturing what it is allegedly intended to capture?

Required readings

- Coale, A.J. (1974). The Demographic Transition. *International Population Conference, Liege*, Vol. 1, 53–72. Liege IUSSP. <https://u.demog.berkeley.edu/jrw/Biblio/Eprints> Key paper by Coale introducing the Ready-Willing-Able framework. In this article, keynote speech, he attempted to summarise the findings of the Princeton European Fertility Transition Project, which we have discussed in class. Coale argues that the onset and the speed of European fertility transitions was contingent on the joint meeting of three preconditions. Focus on those and think about how they may play out in relation to our “culture vs. economics.”
- Kaiser, J. (2011). “Does Family Planning Bring Down Fertility?” *Science* (July 29), pp. 548–549. <http://www.sciencemag.org/content/333/6042/548> Short but very relevant paper discussing the importance of family planning programs in fertility reduction.
- Liu, D. H., and Adrian E. R. (2020). How Do Education and Family Planning Accelerate Fertility Decline? *Population and Development Review*, 46(3): 409–41. <https://doi.org/10.1111/padr.12347> Empirical paper testing the respective and concomitant roles of education & family planning on fertility declines.
- Senderowicz, L., & Valley, T. (2023). Fertility Has Been Framed: Why Family Planning Is Not a Silver Bullet for Sustainable Development. *Studies in Comparative International Development*, 1–32. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12116-023-09410-2>
A recent paper from two critical demography scholars on understanding the framing (by demographers and the international policy community) of family planning. Try to read just before watching Bongaarts's presentation at Hopkins.
- Bongaarts, J. (2017). Importance of Family Planning; Population and Family Planning in Sub-Saharan Africa [YouTube video](#). A talk in which one of the most influential demographers of all time

discusses several questions on the role of family planning in shaping fertility trajectories. Think about Bongaarts' take on the role of family planning, and funding for family planning programs in Africa in relation to Senderowicz and Valley's critique (as well as the timing of each).

Optional readings

Optional readings include a highly readable 11-page overview of proximate determinants of fertility, the framework developed by Bongaarts to understand individual-level behavioural and biological sources of fertility change (here, note the different population patterns in fertility in Figure 11.2 and associated text describing the five patterns; how the differences across population fertility can be visible in different age-specific fertility rates, and then literally just one bullet point each summarising the impact of nutrition and health on fertility), another key paper by Senderowicz and Maloney which criticises the concept of “unmet needs”, a paper of mine where I employ both approaches (proximate determinants + critique of unmet needs) to understand the impacts of conflict on contraceptive use in the Sahel and a paper that finally incorporates men in the discussion of contraception more broadly.

- Bongaarts, J., & Potter, R. E. (2013). Fertility, biology, and behavior: An analysis of the proximate determinants. *Academic Press*, pp. 171-183. <https://doi.org/10.1016/C2009-0-03021-9>
- Senderowicz, L., & Maloney, N. (2022). Supply-Side versus Demand-Side unmet need: implications for family planning programs. *Population and Development Review*, 48(3), 689-722. <https://doi.org/10.1111/padr.12478>
- Torrisi, O. (2024). Violent instability and modern contraception: Evidence from Mali. *World Development*, 177, 106538. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2024.106538>
- Strong, J. (2022). Men's involvement in women's abortion-related care: a scoping review of evidence from low-and middle-income countries. *Sexual and reproductive health matters*, 30(1), 2040774. <https://doi.org/10.1080/26410397.2022.2040774>

WEEK 7 – LOW AND VERY LOW FERTILITY

Core Questions

- What is the “Second Demographic Transition”? How (if it is) is it distinct from the first?
- Why is low fertility an issue for populations in the first place? Is it sure that fertility will continue to drop?
- Will some populations with below replacement fertility become extinct? What, if any, policies should be put in place to increase population size in these countries?
- Is the “gender revolution” a good explanation for below replacement fertility? Will it ultimately lead to replacement-level fertility?

Required readings

- Morgan, S. P. (2003). Is Low Fertility a Twenty-First-Century Demographic Crisis? *Demography*, 40(4): 589-603. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/1515198> A classic for understanding developments into low fertility, although a bit outdated in the statistics and some facts (about US above-replacement fertility, for instance).
- Lesthaeghe, R. (2010). The Unfolding Story of the Second Demographic Transition. *Population and Development Review*, 36(2): 211-51. <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/epdf/10.1111/j.1728-4457.2010.00328.x> Second classic. A piece you will need to focus on and slow down, and try to find your bearings by following the structure (headings and subheadings). Figure 15 and Appendix Table 1 are worth studying in detail.

- Kohler, H. P., Billari, F. C., & Ortega, J. A. (2002). The emergence of lowest-low fertility in Europe during the 1990s. *Population and Development Review*, 28(4), 641-680. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1728-4457.2002.00641.x> Theory-dense (backed up by evidence) paper on the emergence of very low fertility in Europe.
- Goldscheider, F., Bernhard, E., and T. Lappegard. (2015). The Gender Revolution: A Framework for Understanding Changing Family and Demographic Behavior. *Population and Development Review*, 41(2): 207-239. <http://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/j.1728-4457.2015.00045.x/epdf> Third key paper providing a theory – the gender revolution theory – for explaining declines in fertility in high-income societies.

Optional readings

Optional readings include articles detailing other, not less important or necessarily antithetical theories explaining fertility declines (ideational change, gender, diffusion, culture), a review of the main theories, an important paper explaining how the second demographic transition led to stratified (diverging) outcomes within the US (specifically regarding children's resources and wellbeing), and an important recent paper on the sociological consequences of the one-child policy in China, one on the effect of extended parental leave on earnings in Quebec as well as a recent short media piece by two leading US demographers about the impact of social factors on fertility. This latter nicely leads readers through the demographic basics (and details) of fertility and touches on several interesting issues.

- Thornton, A. (2001). The Developmental Paradigm, Reading History Sideways, and Family Change. *Demography*, 38(4), 449-465. <https://doi.org/10.1353/dem.2001.0039>
- McDonald, P. (2000). Gender Equity in Theories of Fertility Transition. *Population and Development Review*, 26(3), 427-439. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1728-4457.2000.00427>
- Zaidi, B., & Morgan, P. (2017). The Second Demographic Transition Theory: A Review and Appraisal. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 43(1), 473-492. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-soc-060116-053442>
- McLanahan, S. (2004). Diverging Destinies: How Children Are Faring under the Second Demographic Transition. *Demography*, 41, 607-627. <https://doi.org/10.1353/dem.2004.0033>
- Myrskylä, M., Kohler, H.-P., & Billari, F. C. (2009). Advances in Development Reverse Fertility Decline. *Nature*, 460, 741-743. <https://doi.org/10.1038/nature08230>
- Goodkind, D. (2017). The Astonishing Population Averted by China's Birth Restrictions: Estimates, Nightmares and Reprogrammed Ambitions. *Demography*, 54, 1375-1400.
- Feng, W., Gu, B., & Cai, Y. (2016). The End of China's One-Child Policy. *Studies in Family Planning*, 47(1), 83-86. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1728-4465.2016.00052.x>
- Cai, Y., & Feng, W. (2021). The Social and Sociological Consequences of China's One-Child Policy. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 47(1), 587-606. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-soc-090220-032839>
- Choi, Y., Margolis, R., & Holm, A. (2025). The Effects of Extended Parental Benefits on Parents' Employment and Earnings in Canada. *Demography*, 11958785. <https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-11958785>
- McCuaig, K. (2021). Canadian election 2021: Will the national child-care plan survive? *The Conversation*. <https://theconversation.com/canadian-election-2021-will-the-national-child-care-plan-survive-166084>

- Hayford, S., & Guzzo, K. B. (2023). A decades-long broken economy screwed over millennials and their decision to delay having kids is fuelling America's historically low birth rate. *Fortune*.
<https://fortune.com/2023/01/12/millennials-broken-economy-delay-children-birthrate>

WEEK 8 – AGE STRUCTURES AND DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND

Core Questions

- Trace one or more countries' age structure through the demographic transition. What happened to its age structure? What factors determined whether or not it experienced a demographic dividend?
- Is the demographic dividend an important factor in fostering economic growth? If so, how? In what countries and under what circumstances? In what other ways might the “youth bulge” be helpful or harmful?

Required readings

- Bloom, D. E., & Canning, D. (2008). Global demographic change: Dimensions and economic significance. *Population and Development Review*, 34, 17-51.
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/25434758.pdf?refreqid=excelsior> An important, dense paper providing a model of economic growth that highlights the positive effects of demographic transitions from high mortality and fertility to low mortality and fertility, but also showcasing the importance of institutions and government policies.
- Crespo Cuaresma, J., Lutz, W., & Sanderson, W. (2014). Is the demographic dividend an education dividend? *Demography*, 51(1), 299-315. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-013-0245-x>
An important paper discussing the importance and role of education in explaining and labour productivity benefits associated with the idea of the demographic dividend. Focus on the overall discussion of prior models, but skip the technicalities.
- Farid, S., & Mostari, M. (2022). Population transition and demographic dividend in Bangladesh: extent and policy implication. *Journal of Social and Economic Development*, 24(1), 108-126.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s40847-021-00173-x> An application of the idea of the demographic dividend and its implications in a low-income setting.
- LaGrafte, D. (2012). The Youth Bulge in Egypt: An Intersection of Demographics, Security, and the Arab Spring. *Journal of Strategic Security*, 5(2): 65-80.
<http://www.jstor.org/stable/26463960> A take from a non-demographer on the role of population's age structures in social change and upheavals. Recall Bongaarts' video on family planning.

Optional readings

Optional readings include a key classic paper on population ageing (note the definition given by Coale) and the role of the three demographic processes in shaping population age structures, an easy read linking population growth, structure, demographic dividend, and variation across world countries, focusing mostly on implications for policy implications, a policy brief on the “steps and challenges” towards attaining a demographic dividend and a newspaper article discussing (with cool visualisations of population pyramids) population ageing in Canada's Northwest Territories. We conclude with two nice demographic descriptions: one on global changes in teenage fertility and one on fertility trends in Sudan. From these, you can infer a little bit about the demographic dividend globally and in the Sudanese society.

- Coale, A. J. (2017). How a population ages or grows younger. In *Population Growth* (pp. 47-58). Routledge. Access the chapter here: <https://osf.io/rpc6m> (The author, Coale, discusses this article in this YouTube video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ek3nc7XtEOU>)

- Graff, M., & Bremner, J. (2014). A practical guide to population and development. Washington, DC: Population Reference Bureau.
<https://www.prb.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/11/demographic-dividend.pdf>
- Gribble, J., & Bremner, J. (2012). The Challenge of Attaining the Demographic Dividend. Policy Brief, Population Reference Bureau. [Access here](#)
- Williams, O. (2022). How the age of Northwest Territories residents is changing. Yellowknife, NT: Cabin Radio. [Access here](#)
- Spoorenberg, T., Carlsen, E. Ø., Flatø, M., Stonawski, M., & Skirbekk, V. (2024). The Global Adolescent Fertility Decline is Counteracted by Increasing Teen Births in Sub-Saharan Africa. *Studies in Family Planning*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/sifp.12273>
- Sieverding, M. (2024). Determinants of persistently high fertility in Sudan. [Access here](#)

WEEK 9 – INTERNATIONAL MIGRATION

Core Questions

- Why do people migrate? Who migrates?
- Is international migration good for the economic well-being of sending countries? Can remittances promote economic development?
- Is international migration good for the economic well-being of receiving countries? Are immigrants the solution to population ageing?
- Does migration research affect policy? If so, how (well)?

Required readings

- Carling, J. (2024). Why Do People Migrate? Fresh Takes on the Foundational Question of Migration Studies. *International Migration Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/01979183241269445> New, excellent account and summary of theories explaining migration behaviour in human societies.
- Bermingham, J. (2001). Immigration: Not a Solution to Problems of Population Decline and Aging. *Population and Environment*, 22(4): 355-363. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/27503749> Old but good paper detailing reasons why a policy intervention often claimed to be a panacea in low-fertility contexts may not be enough.
- De Hass, H. (2012). The Migration and Development Pendulum: A Critical View on Research and Policy. *International Migration* 50(3), 8-25. <http://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/j.1468-2435.2012.00755.x/abstract> Terrific considerations on the debate between migration and development by a leading expert, both from definitional and analytical perspectives.
- Peri, G. (2020). Immigrant Swan Song. *Finance and Development*, 26-29. International Monetary Fund. <https://www.imf.org/Publications/can-immigration-solve-the-demographic-dilemma-peri> Economics professor arguing in favour of immigration policies allowing larger numbers of immigrants to stabilise population growth in ageing advanced economies. Also available as a podcast: [IMF Podcast link](#).
- Natter, K., & Welfens, N. (2024). Why Has Migration Research So Little Impact? Examining Knowledge Practices in Migration Policy Making and Migration Studies. *International Migration Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/019791832412716> Super recent paper (published 1 month ago) discussing why migration research has not significantly influenced policy-making.

Optional readings

Optional readings include a paper that explores the debate on migration and development by compar-

ing the experiences of major migrant-sending countries and examines the extent to which migration has contributed to their socioeconomic development, papers on the impacts of refugees on receiving communities, a nice article providing experimental evidence on reasons behind migration decision-making and one which discusses the opposite, i.e., immobility. Finally, a paper discussing innovative data sources for migration research.

- Castles, S. (2017). Comparing the Experience of Five Major Emigration Countries. 197–224 in *Migration, Citizenship and Identity*. Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://www.migrationinstitute.org/publications/wp-07-07/@@download/file>
- Aksu, E., Erzan, R., & Kırdar, M. G. (2022). The impact of mass migration of Syrians on the Turkish labor market. *Labour Economics*, 76, 102183. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.labeco.2022.102183>
- Fallah, B., Krafft, C., & Wahba, J. (2019). The impact of refugees on employment and wages in Jordan. *Journal of Development Economics*, 139, 203-216. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jdeveco.2019.03.009>
- Schewel, K. (2020). Understanding immobility: Moving beyond the mobility bias in migration studies. *International Migration Review*, 54(2), 328-355. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0197918319831952>
- Hager, A. (2021). What drives migration to Europe? Survey experimental evidence from Lebanon. *International Migration Review*, 55(3), 929-950. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0197918320988662>
- Rampazzo, F., Bijak, J., Vitali, A., Weber, I., & Zagheni, E. (2024). Assessing timely migration trends through digital traces: a case study of the UK before Brexit. *International Migration Review*, 01979183241247009. <https://doi.org/10.1177/01979183241247009>

WEEK 10 – URBANISATION AND INTERNAL MIGRATION

Core Questions

- What are some of the methodological challenges to measuring migration, internal migration in particular?
- Compare and contrast rural-to-urban migration in high-income and low-income countries. What are the implications of rural-to-urban migration for both rural communities and urban cities? How would they compare to the experiences of migrants in high-income countries?
- What may be the implications of urbanisation for health (mental and physical) and quality of life in low- and middle-income countries?

Required readings

- Kirchberger, M. (2021). Measuring Internal Migration. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, 91:103714. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.regsciurbeco.2021.103714> A nice review of the methods and gaps in the measurement of internal migration.
- Johnson, K. M., & Lichter, D. T. (2019). Rural depopulation: Growth and decline processes over the past century. *Rural Sociology*, 84(1), 3-27. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ruso.12266> This article highlights the rise and geographic spread of depopulation in rural US over the past century, and describes the interplay between out-migration and natural decrease.

- Glaeser, E. (2011). Cities, Productivity, and Quality of Life. *Science*, 333:592-94. <http://doi.org/10.1126/science.120926> A perspective on the benefits, but also potentially detrimental consequences of increasing urbanisation in low- and middle-income settings.
- Harpham, T. (2009). Urban health in developing countries: what do we know and where do we go? *Health & Place*, 15(1), 107-116. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.healthplace.2008.03.004> A thorough review of determinants and outcomes of urban health. It also addresses remaining challenges and research avenues.

Optional readings

Optional readings include a detailed paper using mainstream theories in migration to provide explanations of migration patterns in this country, a broad introduction to internal migration patterns in the African continent, a very recent paper integrating perspectives on migration, policy and fertility ideals in the US, an important article showcasing methods to estimate the size of unauthorised migrants in the US, one exploring rural depopulation and its consequences for growth and one which uses big social network data to attempt to provide 'live' estimates of internal displacement in Ukraine. Finally, a fascinating take on the potential impacts of urbanisation on mental health in low- and middle-income countries. Notice the date of writing!

- Amirault, D., de Munnik, D., and Miller, S. (2013). Explaining Canada's Regional Migration Patterns. *Bank of Canada Review*. <http://www.bankofcanada.ca/wp-content.pdf>
- Teye, J. (2018). Urbanization and Migration in Africa. UNDP. [Access here](#)
- Behrman, J. A., & Weitzman, A. (2024). State-Level Immigrant Policies and Ideal Family Size in the United States. *Population and Development Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/padr.12621>
- Johnson, K., and Lichter, D. (2019). Rural Depopulation: Growth and Decline Processes over the Past Century. *Rural Sociology*, 84(1), 3-27. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ruso.12266>
- Van Hook, J., Morse, A., Capps, R., & Gelatt, J. (2021). Uncertainty about the size of the unauthorized foreign-born population in the United States. *Demography*, 58(6), 2315-2336.
- Leasure, D. R., Kashyap, R., Rampazzo, F., Dooley, C. A., Elbers, B., Bondarenko, M., ... & Mills, M. C. (2023). Nowcasting daily population displacement in Ukraine through social media advertising data. *Population and Development Review*, 49(2), 231-254. <https://doi.org/10.1111/padr.12558>
- Harpham, T. (1994). Urbanization and mental health in developing countries: a research role for social scientists, public health professionals and social psychiatrists. *Social Science & Medicine*, 39(2), 233-245. [http://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536\(94\)90332-8](http://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536(94)90332-8)

WEEK 11 – LIFECOURSE TRANSITIONS (TO ADULthood)

Core Questions

- How have the transitions to adulthood changed over the last 50 years? Do these changes reflect structural changes or preference changes (agency)?
- What, if any, transitions are essential markers of adulthood? Is there an ideal pathway into adulthood? How does the timing of one transition impact other transitions?
- How do the transitions to adulthood differ by gender, socioeconomic status, rural/urban residence, and/or region? Why might these differences matter? What do these differences imply about the concept of adulthood?

Required readings

- Manning, W. (2020). Young Adulthood Relationships in an Era of Uncertainty: A Case for Cohabitation. *Demography*, 57(3), 799-819. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.2307/48681383> An important piece by a leading family demographer showcasing the importance of cohabitation for understanding transitions to adulthood among “Millennials”.
- Pike, I., Mojola, S. A., & Kabiru, C. W. (2018). Making sense of marriage: Gender and the transition to adulthood in Nairobi, Kenya. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 80(5), 1298-1313. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12525> Nice qualitative piece by McGill Sociology’s Prof Pike exploring understandings of marriage in a society undergoing normative changes.
- Billari, F. C., & Liefbroer, A. C. (2010). Towards a new pattern of transition to adulthood? *Advances in Life Course Research*, 15(2-3), 59-75. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.alcr.2010.10.003> Excellent paper examining the hypothesis of a convergence towards a specific ideal-typical pathway to adulthood in Europe. Focus particularly on the theoretical framework, slowly.

Optional readings

Optional readings include a dense paper using nice visualisations to explore changes in women’s transition to adulthood patterns in low- and middle-income countries, a report looking at changes in young adulthood in the US 40 years, and a scholarly paper discussing largely the same ideas, as well as a comparison of changes between three Anglophone countries. Finally, a paper that touches upon an increasingly debated issue, housing.

- Pesando, L. M., Barban, N., Sironi, M., & Furstenberg, F. F. (2021). A sequence-analysis approach to the study of the transition to adulthood in low-and middle-income countries. *Population and Development Review*, 47(3), 719-747. <https://doi.org/10.1111/padr.12425>
- Vespa, J. (2017). The Changing Economics and Demographics of Young Adulthood: 1975-2016. Current Populations Reports. Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau. <http://www.piasd.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/04/Changing-Economics-Demo-of-Young-Adulthood.pdf>
- Shanahan, M. J. (2000). Pathways to Adulthood in Changing Societies: Variability and Mechanisms in Life Course Perspective. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 26, 667-. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.soc.26.1.667>
- Fussell, E., Gauthier, A. H., & Evans, A. (2007). Heterogeneity in the transition to adulthood: The cases of Australia, Canada, and the United States. *European Journal of Population/Revue européenne de démographie*, 23, 389-414. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10680-007-9136-4>
- Ford, J., Rugg, J., & Burrows, R. (2002). Conceptualising the Contemporary Role of Housing in the Transition to Adult Life in England. *Urban Studies*, 39(13), 2455-2467. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0042098022000027059>

WEEK 12 – TOPICS IN FAMILY DEMOGRAPHY AND EMERGING THEMES

Core Questions

- What constitutes a family?
- What is the future of marriage as an institution?
- How do divorce and re-partnering affect intergenerational relationships?
- What has a greater impact on children’s and adolescents’ well-being: family structure, family composition, or family stability?

Required readings

- Cherlin, A. J. (2020). Degrees of Change: An Assessment of the Deinstitutionalization of Marriage Thesis. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 82(1), 62–80. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12605> Cherlin revisits his earlier argument on the "deinstitutionalisation of marriage" in the US. He previously claimed that the norms guiding marriage were weakening, particularly as society became more secular and inclusive of diverse family types. Does he still support this view? Has marriage shifted from being an early marker of adulthood to a prestige status — a capstone of adult life?
- Smock, P. J., & Schwartz, C. (2020). The Demography of Families: A Review of Patterns and Change. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 82(1), 9–34. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12> A recent review of patterns and changes in family demography and family dynamics in the United States.
- Lin, I. F., Brown, S. L., & Mellencamp, K. A. (2022). The Roles of Grey Divorce and Subsequent Re-partnering for Parent–Adult Child Relationships. *The Journals of Gerontology: Series B*, 77(1), 212–223. <https://doi.org/10.1093/geronb/gbab139> This article links late-life family dissolution to the quality of parent–adult child relationships, highlighting differences between mothers' and fathers' relationships with their children after grey divorce.

Optional readings

Optional readings for the week include a range of topics related to family change as well as papers in critical demography. If there is interest, I may add or replace some studies that explore how family forms respond to crises (e.g., violence, natural disasters, environmental change).

Extra Readings on Family Change and Living Arrangements

These include a recent qualitative paper reassessing Cherlin's deinstitutionalisation of marriage thesis, a paper illustrating the diversity of family forms, and examples of demographic work without access to vital statistics. Additional readings address father absence and LGB family formation.

- Sassler, S., & Miller, A. J. (2023). Assessing the deinstitutionalization of marriage thesis: Changes in the meaning of cohabitation over the relationship life course. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 85(2), 370–390. [doi:10.1111/jomf.12883](https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12883)
- Clark, S., & Brauner-Otto, S. (2015). Divorce in sub-Saharan Africa: Are unions becoming less stable? *Population and Development Review*, 41(4), 583–605. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24638576>
- Margolis, R., Choi, Y., Hou, F., & Haan, M. (2019). Capturing trends in Canadian divorce in an era without vital statistics. *Demographic Research*, 41, 1453–1478. <https://www.demographic-research.org/volumes/vol41/52/41-52.pdf>
- Nobles, J. (2011). Parenting from abroad: Migration, non-resident father involvement, and children's education in Mexico. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 73(4), 729–746. [doi:10.1111/j.1741-3737.2011.00842.x](https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2011.00842.x)
- Ophir, A., Boertien, D., & Vidal, S. (2023). Sexuality and demographic change: Documenting family formation trajectories and cohort change in the LGB population. *Demography*, 60(5), 1581–1605. [doi:10.1215/00703370-10968468](https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-10968468)
- Furstenberg, F. F., Harris, L. E., Pesando, L. M., & Reed, M. N. (2020). Kinship practices among alternative family forms in Western industrialised societies. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 82(5), 1403–1430. [doi:10.1111/jomf.12712](https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12712)
- Manning, W. D., Westrick-Payne, K., & Gates, G. J. (2022). Cohabitation and marriage among same-sex couples in the 2019 ACS and CPS: A research note. *Demography*, 59(5), 1595–1605. [doi:10.1215/00703370-10181474](https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-10181474)

Extra Readings on Critical and Queer Demography, Race, and Measurement

These readings invite critical reflection on demographic categories, assumptions in reproductive health research, and the implications of population classifications.

- Horton, H. D. (1999). Critical Demography: The Paradigm of the Future? *Sociological Forum*, 14, 363–367. [doi:10.1023/A:1021491317725](https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1021491317725)
- Lagos, D. (2018). Looking at Population Health Beyond ‘Male’ and ‘Female’: Implications of Transgender Identity and Gender Nonconformity for Population Health. *Demography*, 55(6), 2097–2117. [doi:10.1007/s13524-018-0714-3](https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-018-0714-3)
- Westbrook, L., & Saperstein, A. (2015). New Categories Are Not Enough: Rethinking the Measurement of Sex and Gender in Social Surveys. *Gender & Society*, 29(4), 534–560. [doi:10.1177/0891243215584758](https://doi.org/10.1177/0891243215584758)
- Agadjanian, A. (2022). How Many Americans Change Their Racial Identification over Time? *Socius*, 8. [doi:10.1177/23780231221098547](https://doi.org/10.1177/23780231221098547)
- VandeVusse, A. J., Mueller, J., Kirstein, M., Strong, J., & Lindberg, L. D. (2023). “Technically an abortion”: Understanding perceptions and definitions of abortion in the United States. *Social Science & Medicine*, 335, 116216. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2023.116216>
- Strong, J., Nandagiri, R., Randall, S., & Coast, E. (2023). Qualitative research in demography: marginal and marginalised. In *How to conduct qualitative research in social science* (pp. 147–163). Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781800376199.00015>
- Cohen, P. (2021). Generation labels mean nothing. It’s time to retire them. *The Washington Post*. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2021/07/07/generation-labels-mean-nothing-retire-them>
- Nobles, J., Cannon, L., & Wilcox, A. J. (2022). Menstrual irregularity as a biological limit to early pregnancy awareness. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 119(1), e2113762118. [doi:10.1073/pnas.2113762118](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2113762118)

WEEK 13 – POSTER PRESENTATIONS